

Chapter 9 - Jade Pendant

"Wenzhou!" Ning Fuyi broke out in a cold sweat and hurriedly rushed over to pull her away. Fortunately, although Liu Wenzhou's cultivation couldn't compare to Li Chaoan's, she was still the eldest daughter of the Liu family and wasn't afraid in the slightest. Instead, she summoned a barrier with her other hand, blocking that white light.

The wind from their immortal power blew apart their hair, creating a ripple-like energy wave that swept up dust all over the floor.

Seeing Liu Wenzhou completely unharmed, the heart that Ning Fuyi had lifted finally relaxed somewhat. However, the evil qi in her heart grew even denser, and the look she gave Li Chaoan carried killing intent.

"With such cultivation level, you still want to fight me!" Li Chaoan showed no mercy whatsoever. She pushed aside her companions, then drew a circle on her chest, causing crackling lightning to gather in her palm.

As she circulated her power, the surrounding wind grew stronger, and even the sky seemed to darken. Liu Wenzhou was startled and waved her hand to resist, but her sleeve corner was suddenly grabbed, stopping her movement.

She turned back in surprise to find Ning Fuyi had somehow moved behind her, currently speaking clearly and lowly into her ear: "No need to resist forcefully. Listen to my incantation."

With Ning Fuyi's shallow cultivation, where would she get an incantation? Though very surprised, Liu Wenzhou trusted that Ning Fuyi wouldn't harm her, so she immediately stopped her movements.

"Furnace fire illuminates heaven and earth, red stars disturb purple smoke. A thousand times taken from the palm, startling thunder falls on cold streams."

Following Ning Fuyi's guidance, Liu Wenzhou gently waved her long sleeves and gathered a semicircle from mid-air, like a scorching canopy that pressed down toward Li Chaoan. The lightning that Li Chaoan had been building up in her hands gradually weakened. Her expression grew somewhat panicked, and she hurriedly switched techniques to resist Liu Wenzhou's fierce fire.

"Thunder needs guidance; breaking heaven and earth destroys it," Ning Fuyi said again.

Hearing this, Liu Wenzhou suddenly changed her hand gesture, and they heard a sharp scream, like an exploding bird's nest, so noisy it hurt their ears. Ning Fuyi waved her hand to sweep away the incoming heat wave, and when she looked carefully, she almost laughed out loud.

Li Chaoan's originally charming face was now covered with a layer of soot, the colorful garland on her head had turned black, and even her carefully arranged bangs had been burned off in one spot, making her look quite comical.

"Liu Wenzhou, you!" Li Chaoan covered her hair, stomped her feet angrily, and almost burst into tears on the spot.

Seeing this, Liu Wenzhou patted her chest to calm her nerves while unable to resist tugging at Ning Fuyi's sleeve, whispering: "Yiyi, this incantation is so powerful. How do you know..."

"Ning Changfeng taught me. I couldn't practice it, but I memorized it," Ning Fuyi answered vaguely to avoid suspicion.

Although she had no cultivation now, in her previous life she had at least reached that level of mastery. Having specialized in lightning techniques, she naturally knew how to counter Li Chaoan's petty tricks - she just couldn't execute them herself.

It was fortunate that Liu Wenzhou was clever and understood immediately.

Li Chaoan cared most about face, and being so disheveled now, how could she dare show herself? Just then, several disciples were walking in from outside. Both ashamed and angry, she pointed her fingers at Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhou, telling them not to get cocky, then turned and ran away as if flying.

She left only her two friends to fight for her honor. One was short and fat, the other tall and thin - standing together, they were quite amusing.

"We were just sparring, yet Liu Wenzhou actually injured someone!" the fat one said loudly.

"That's right, Chaoan treasures her hair the most, you two..."

"What about us? You demanded to spar, but you have no ability yourselves, yet expect others to yield to you - what kind of logic is that?" Ning Fuyi tilted her head and smiled, returning their words with interest.

These two hadn't left much impression on her in her previous life, so she couldn't remember their names. They seemed to be called something like Shaobing¹ and Miantiao², she thought.

Thinking this, she called out these names, and as soon as the words left her mouth, Liu Wenzhou beside her burst into giggles, covering her red lips as she laughed until her whole body shook.

Meanwhile, the faces of the two across from them turned as black as charcoal.

What was wrong? Ning Fuyi raised an eyebrow.

"Ning Fuyi, when you can't argue back, you make up nicknames for people!" The young woman was so angry her face turned purple like a grape. "Our names were given by our parents, yet you mock us with this - how vicious!"

"Just you wait!" she said angrily, then pulled her companion along and turned to chase after Li Chaoan.

"One is called Shao Bing, the other Mian Tiao³. What Shaobing and Miantiao - you really thought that up," Liu Wenzhou whispered in Ning Fuyi's ear, her shoulders trembling.

Oh, so she had remembered wrong. Ning Fuyi nodded.

Ning Fuyi had originally wanted to have a proper verbal battle, but one slip of the tongue had driven everyone away, leaving her quite bored. She could only pull along Liu Wenzhou, who couldn't stop laughing, and listlessly entered the hall.

North Garden had the most ordinary decorations. Whether the courtyards or halls, almost everything was made of granite. This wasn't to mistreat disciples with lower cultivation - it was because young disciples mostly couldn't control their immortal power well and would often destroy North Garden completely during cultivation. Ning Changfeng had repaired it over ten times and finally couldn't bear it anymore. In anger, she procured the hardest granite and renovated the entire North Garden.

Ning Fuyi walked through the fellow disciples who were whispering about her and swaggered into the teaching hall, finding a corner to settle down comfortably.

"Yiyi, I heard there's important business today - all the elders are coming to North Garden. Don't sleep, or you'll get scolded again," Liu Wenzhou reached out to tug at Ning Fuyi's sleeve, trying to pull her up.

"Let them scold all they want. It's just about immortal meridians and immortal power - I'm a waste who can't learn anyway." The thoroughly corrupted Ning Fuyi played dead completely, lifting her head to change direction and lying back down.

Liu Wenzhou was anxious for her and was about to forcefully pull her up when she saw a tall, elegant man enter through the doorway. Her eyes lit up and she forcefully poked Ning Fuyi's waist: "Yiyi, get up quickly! Senior Brother Rong Jin⁴ is here!"

She didn't control her strength with this poke and nearly punctured Ning Fuyi's spleen. Ning Fuyi cried out in pain and straightened her back, grimacing.

"Liu Wenzhou, you..." Ning Fuyi couldn't speak. You had to know that although Liu Wenzhou looked delicate and refined, she actually possessed tremendous strength - she could uproot the thousand-year-old weeping willow outside the door without using immortal power, then replant it right-side up.

So this poke nearly took half her life.

Only then did Liu Wenzhou realize her mistake and repeatedly apologized: "Sorry, sorry, sorry, Yiyi..."

"It's fine." Ning Fuyi waved her hand while holding back tears. When the pain subsided, she looked toward the entrance.

The familiar figure had his hair meticulously bound in a white jade crown, wearing the deep blue robes of a senior disciple. His back was straight and upright, with a lotus wood carving hanging at his waist - the same as Liu Wenzhou's, also a birthday gift from Ning Fuyi.

Except his wood carving looked quite crooked, carved when Ning Fuyi was just learning.

Ning Fuyi blinked, concealing the sourness in her eyes.

Ning Fuyi considered herself unlikeable, and the facts confirmed this. From childhood, few people had treated her well. The sect disciples avoided open conflict with her due to Ning Changfeng's influence, but they looked down on her behind her back. The elders thought she lacked talent and didn't strive to improve, so they never gave her a kind face.

So no matter how she counted on her fingers, aside from Ning Changfeng and Liu Wenzhou, the only person who could be said to treat her well was Senior Brother Rong Jin.

Rong Jin was a good person - actually, an overly good person. This was why Ning Fuyi thought Rong Jin treated her well, and precisely because of this, when young Ning Changfeng found her troublesome and didn't want to care for her, she would always dump her on Rong Jin.

And Rong Jin lived up to expectations. An unmarried young man spent entire days researching feeding and baby care, forcing himself to become a qualified wet nurse. When Ning Fuyi was small, all her clothes were hand-sewn by him - truly dedicated.

Over time, Ning Fuyi genuinely came to respect him like an elder brother.

Later, when Ning Fuyi entered the demonic path, she made the righteously-minded Rong Jin so angry he fell seriously ill. Ning Fuyi had thought they would become strangers from then on, but who would have known that later when she was seriously injured and hunted by immortals, Rong Jin turned against his allies at the critical moment, pushing her out of the demon-slaying formation.

He himself lost the chance to escape and was struck by heavenly thunder before Ning Fuyi's eyes, reduced to dust.

Although Rong Jin was now standing perfectly fine before her, when the memories surged up, Ning Fuyi still felt her heart ache as if pierced by needles.

The distant Rong Jin's gaze swept over everyone and finally settled on Ning Fuyi. Perhaps seeing something wrong with her expression, he quickly walked toward her.

"Fuyi, how are you?" he asked with concern.

"It's nothing, just a bit tired," Ning Fuyi stared at his face and answered quietly.

She suddenly felt grateful to fate for allowing her life to end less miserably, for letting her live again.

"I originally wanted to visit you, but every time I went to Pearl Light Pavilion, they said you were resting, so I only see you today." Rong Jin's words were full of heartache. "About the sect master's matter..."

"It's really fine, thank you, senior brother." Ning Fuyi rarely spoke so gently.

Her dark eyes were wide open, her face had little color, and her speech was soft - in Rong Jin's eyes, she looked even more frail and vulnerable.

Rong Jin sighed heavily but didn't say more. Instead, he suddenly took out a milk-white jade pendant from his robes and handed it to Ning Fuyi.

"This is a Ziwu Jade⁵. I won it in a competition with others when I followed Daoist Yuanming⁶ to Zhaoyao Mountain this time. It has the effect of condensing immortal power - if you wear it, cultivation will be easier in the future."

"Senior brother, this is too precious, I..." Ning Fuyi was about to say she had no use for it, but Rong Jin had already grasped the red cord on both sides and reached out to put it on her.

Not wanting to refuse his good intentions, Ning Fuyi let the jade pendant fall against her neck, where it warmed upon contact with her skin.

Just as she was about to thank him, she suddenly felt the surrounding atmosphere freeze instantly. The previously chattering hall fell silent as death, quiet enough to make one's heart race. The surrounding disciples all sat properly in their seats, heads down looking at their desks, none daring to make a sound.

Liu Wenzhou nearby coughed loudly and urgently. Rong Jin instinctively turned sideways, revealing a pair of eyes cold as an ice cellar from behind his shoulder.

"Chu, Chu Ling Divine Venerable," Rong Jin stammered.

Chu Qingqiu? What was she doing here? Ning Fuyi looked up in surprise, seeing she still wore plain clothes, her long black hair half-draped behind her, standing coldly across from them.

The injuries on her body seemed completely healed, showing no trace of the frailty from two days ago.

She ignored Rong Jin and instead gently reached out her hand, her fingertip sliding across the back of Ning Fuyi's neck, leaving a cool sensation. Ning Fuyi's body trembled and she tried to dodge sideways, but Chu Qingqiu had already withdrawn her hand.

The jade pendant had somehow been removed by Chu Qingqiu, who held it loosely by the red cord, swaying it in mid-air.

"Chu Qingqiu, you..." Seeing the jade pendant taken away, Ning Fuyi frowned and was about to argue with her, but was interrupted.

"This object gathers spiritual energy but doesn't release it. Wearing it on the body not only doesn't help cultivation but actually harms the immortal meridians," Chu Qingqiu said, slowly placing her fingers on the table and setting down the jade pendant.

Hearing this, Rong Jin widened his eyes in fear.

"The si hour⁷ has arrived. Why are you still standing?" Chu Qingqiu spoke again. Rong Jin didn't dare disobey and could only use his gaze to apologize to Ning Fuyi, then restored his composure as a senior disciple and quickly left.

Ning Fuyi was quite confused. She glared at Chu Qingqiu with her eyes but could only obediently sit down.

Chu Qingqiu's presence lingered beside her for a while before silently passing by, stirring up a small breeze. A gardenia petal fluttered down and landed before her eyes.

Ning Fuyi reached out to pick up the petal, and suddenly a string of golden characters visible only to her flashed before her eyes.

"When the immortal teaching ends, come to my room."

Footnotes:

¹ Shaobing (烧饼) - A type of Chinese flatbread, literally "baked cake"

² Miantiao (面条) - Noodles

³ The actual names are Shao Bing (邵冰) and Mian Tiao (缅跳), which sound similar to the food items

⁴ Rong Jin (容锦) - Ning Fuyi's senior brother figure; "Rong" means "to contain/accommodate," "Jin" means "brocade/tapestry"

⁵ Ziwu Jade (子午玉) - A type of spiritual jade, named after the Ziwu (子午) time period in traditional Chinese timekeeping

⁶ Daoist Yuanming (元明道人) - A Daoist master; "Yuanming" means "original brightness"

⁷ Si hour (巳时) - In traditional Chinese timekeeping, corresponds to 9-11 AM